

sweet SUCCESS

Winning the Green Oscar for their very first production, *Living on the Edge*

biggest OBSTACLE

Ever changing media guidelines. But hurdles are turned into opportunities.

on their GROWTH

Plan to launch a Hindi entertainment channel with Turner



NIKHIL AND NIRET
AT THEIR HOME
IN DELHI

HEMANT CHAWLA

NIKHIL
ALVA, 39

NIRET
ALVA, 42

ENTERTAINMENT PROFESSIONALS
CO-FOUNDERS, MIDITECH
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1992 RS 1,00,000
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 100 crore

NOT CONTENT YET

Much before reality shows were a gleam in small town India's eyes, the Brothers Alva had seen the future. Much before *Indian Idol* made winners out of Darjeeling policemen and MTV Roadies elevated dhaba owners from Saharanpur, Miditech had an award winning show on BBC World in 2000 called *Hospital*. "We knew soaps would become less relevant and reality shows would create a buzz," says Niret Alva, 42, co-founder of Miditech along with brother Nikhil Alva, 39. Working out of Delhi, the Alvas, sons of Congress leader Margaret Alva who resigned recently from all her party posts, are full of ideas. Reality is their forte, but their range is wide, from *Gali Gali Sim Sim* for children to *Indian Idol 4*, from animation to their first love, documentaries. "We are probably the only company producing for MTV and National Geographic," says Niret, who adds that the show that opened doors for them

was their very first, *Living on the Edge*, which aired over more than 200 episodes on Doordarshan and got them the Green Oscar.

With over 400 hours of programming a year for numerous channels, the company has grown literally one show at a time. "It would be lovely to say, it was all beautifully planned and chartered, but unfortunately that's not how it has been," says Niret. They are all set to become even more adventurous, with a Hindi entertainment channel by early next year, as a joint venture with Turner International. Niret hates discussing figures and says, "that side of the business is handled by Nikhil," but both are Stephanians, Niret a history graduate and Nikhil a mathematics graduate.

Miditech which started with the brothers and two friends working out of their home has now grown into one of Asia's biggest production houses employing over 150 professionals with offices in Bangalore, Mumbai, Gurgaon and Singapore. Nikhil says, "We want Miditech to grow into an international production house." In the age of reality TV, anything is possible. **by Nirmala Ravindran**